

7.4.4.1 Pedagogy for The World Around Us

Environment, for students in the Preparatory Stage, is what is immediately around them and affects their lives. Students learn about the environment through structured interaction with their natural and social environment, exploration, discussion of experiences and observations, interaction with adults and peers, exemplars, task-oriented activities, structured observations, experiments, surveys, and visits.

This engagement with the immediate environment provides a base for moving into exploring larger systems (from locality to district to region to state to nation to world), broader issues (from home to community to larger society), and an expanding understanding of concerns, connections, and consequences. Thus, students' engagement with their immediate environment leads them to an understanding of distant environments — they are able to apply their understanding from 'near' to 'far', and vice versa.

Values and dispositions — e.g., collaboration, respect for diversity, inclusion, scientific temper, sensitivity towards the social and natural environment are best developed if they are demonstrated — by adults in the school. Students must also get the opportunity to practise them in their interactions.

7.4.4.1.1 Pedagogical Approaches

Students' questions and experiences — related to the social and physical environment, and of social processes around them (including schools and family) — must be given space. This establishes trust and empathy between the Teacher and students.

Teachers need to help students develop conceptual understanding instead of accumulating facts. This implies that sufficient time must be provided for surveys, exploration, visits to institutions, excursions (including within the school campus), observation, experiments, simple inquiry, dialogue with Teachers and peers, role play, questioning, and the communication of ideas.

Task-oriented work, wherein they take up some small tasks, helps students connect learning to doing. Through the creation of simple models and toys, they can communicate their understanding and make learning concrete in the process. Allowing students to take the lead in material development, through a variety of modes like art and craft, story, drama, and hands-on experiments provides space for them to be involved in several small-scale and large-scale assignments and projects. This is also invaluable for the development of prevocational capacities.

Teachers must also be aware of values and dispositions that can be developed through activities, and plan deliberately to offer students experiences. They should also make the values and dispositions explicit for students by drawing attention to them. They should also make them explicit for students by drawing attention to specific values and dispositions (e.g., collaborative learning, developing a scientific temper, working in diverse groups, analysing work distribution at home, caring for the environment, cleanliness, standing in queues).

Bal Shodh Mela

I teach Grades 3, 4, and 5 in a rural school. Over the years, Bal Shodh Melas have become an integral part of my pedagogy to give my students an interdisciplinary exposure. Bal Shodh Melas or Children's Research Festivals are intended to encourage students' inherent sense of curiosity and interest in exploring their surroundings, and excitement to engage with new learning. Bal Shodh Melas encourage students to engage in research.

I scaffold them to conduct simple inquiries on local issues/topics by formulating questions, collecting data, and drawing conclusions. The process encourages creative expression, and independent reading and writing, as well as collaboration among students. It is also a wonderful way for me to strengthen relations with the community, since community members are also invited to the mela organised to close the process. Through this process, learning happens in an integrated way – capacities developed across subjects are used by students, and learning is concretised within their own contexts.

A few illustrative topics that my students have taken up for research are – my house; the history of our village/area; the geographical and natural location of our area; trees and vegetation around us; business and work, birds, and animals around us; means of transport; demography of our village/ward; local folklore and folk tales; folk sayings and phrases.

I have fellow Teachers who use this even in crowded urban contexts as there is plenty of scope for exploration there too. For example, towns and cities go through a tremendous change and usually have people from diverse communities living there, not all of whom are originally from there. So, students can collect stories such as – when was a shop set up; where is the shopkeeper originally from; what conditions prompted them to migrate, and so on. After all, the objective is to collect stories – and what can be more interesting than the stories of the people around us?